

Major car repair decision worksheet

Use this checklist before approving a major car repair, replacing your car, trading it in, or selling it as-is.

Keep safety separate from the cost comparison. If the vehicle may be unsafe, ask a qualified professional whether it should be driven before delaying or declining work.

01 Questions to ask the mechanic

- ☐ What problem did you find?
- ☐ How did you confirm the diagnosis?
- ☐ Is the repair urgent?
- ☐ Is the vehicle safe to drive right now?
- ☐ What does this repair fix?
- ☐ What does this repair not fix?
- ☐ Are there related parts or systems that should be inspected?
- ☐ Is the estimate written and itemized?
- ☐ What parts are being used: new, used, rebuilt, remanufactured, aftermarket, or OEM?
- ☐ What warranty covers parts and labor?
- ☐ What could happen if I wait?
- ☐ Would you approve this repair if it were your car? Why or why not?

02 Numbers to compare

Repair quote: \$ _____

Diagnostic fees: \$ _____

Taxes and shop fees: \$ _____

Likely additional repairs in the next 12 months: \$ _____

Transportation while the car is being repaired: \$ _____

Current estimated vehicle value: \$ _____

Remaining loan balance: \$ _____

Estimated trade-in or as-is sale value: \$ _____

Used replacement purchase price: \$ _____

New replacement purchase price: \$ _____

Down payment: \$ _____

Estimated APR: _____ %

Loan term: _____ months

Taxes, title, registration, and dealer fees: \$ _____

Monthly insurance change: \$ _____

Monthly fuel change: \$ _____

Monthly maintenance change: \$ _____

Comparison period:

☐ 12 months

☐ 24 months

☐ 36 months

03 Warning signs before approving the repair

- ☐ The car may not be safe to drive.
 - ☐ The diagnosis is unclear.
 - ☐ The estimate is not written or itemized.
 - ☐ The repair has little or no warranty.
 - ☐ The shop cannot explain what caused the problem.
 - ☐ The repair only fixes one part of a larger failure.
 - ☐ The car has serious rust, flood, structural, brake, steering, airbag, or tire concerns.
 - ☐ The car has stranded you more than once recently.
 - ☐ You would need to borrow money for the repair and still might not trust the car.
 - ☐ The repair cost is close to or higher than the realistic replacement path.
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04 When to get a second estimate

- ☐ The quote is expensive.
- ☐ The diagnosis is unclear.
- ☐ The car is safe enough to inspect elsewhere or can be towed.
- ☐ The repair involves engine, transmission, hybrid battery, electrical, structural, brake, or steering work.
- ☐ The warranty terms are hard to understand.
- ☐ The repair quote changed significantly after the first estimate.
- ☐ You feel rushed and the car is not an immediate safety risk.

05 When repairing may make sense

- ☐ The repair is clearly diagnosed.
 - ☐ The car is otherwise safe and dependable.
 - ☐ The repair is likely to buy enough usable time.
 - ☐ Replacement would create a much higher total cost.
 - ☐ The car is paid off or has a manageable loan balance.
 - ☐ The repair warranty is clear.
 - ☐ You have realistic confidence that no second major repair is close behind.
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06 When replacing may make sense

- ☐ The car is unsafe or unreliable.
- ☐ Several major systems are aging at the same time.
- ☐ The repair is one of many expected repairs.
- ☐ You need reliable transportation for work, caregiving, school, or medical needs.
- ☐ The car has negative equity and repeated repair risk.
- ☐ A realistic replacement would reduce downtime and uncertainty.
- ☐ Selling or trading in as-is may be better than repairing first.

07 Notes

Mechanic or shop:

Repair estimate notes:

Replacement assumptions:

Decision I am leaning toward:

- ☐ Repair
- ☐ Replace used
- ☐ Replace new
- ☐ Sell as-is
- ☐ Trade in
- ☐ Get another estimate first

Next action:
